example, adding additional steps in a mortgage application process may be perceived as being cumbersome and annoying for the banker selling the mortgage and for the client applying for a house loan. But the net effect of reducing the risk of bad loans may be considered beneficial enough for the bank as a whole to outweigh these disadvantages. It's important to be aware of these negative impacts, and to try to minimize them where possible.

Many different types of stakeholders will be interested in the outcomes of your work. Future users of your product are probably the most obvious example; their daily work will be impacted by your project, for better or for worse. For the Frequent Flyer website, this category of stakeholder will include current and future Frequent Flyer members. It may also include call center staff, who will have to answer questions from Frequent Flyer members about the new program and be able to view a client's current status and miles. They may also need to perform more complicated tasks that are not yet supported on the Frequent Flyer website, such as transferring Frequent Flyer miles between family members or crediting earned miles manually.

Note that future users may not always be directly interested in the business goals. A Frequent Flyer member has no particular reason to want to see an increase in Flying High ticket sales. Sometimes what the user wants and asks for will have little or no bearing on the original business objectives. When you think about what features you need to deliver to achieve the business goals, you need to think in terms of how you can encourage these stakeholders to behave in a way that helps you achieve the goals. For example, you'll want to provide features that encourage users to book flights with Flying High rather than with a competitor in order to increase ticket sales revenue.

Another category of stakeholder includes people who won't be using the application themselves, but who are directly affected by, or interested in, the outcomes of the project. For example, Bill is the Director of Sales at Flying High Airlines and is therefore responsible for ticket sales. An increase in ticket sales revenue of 5% will help him meet his own goals of increasing sales revenue in general. In addition, his budget is paying for the new Frequent Flyer members' website, so understanding and quantifying this business goal will give Bill a way to justify the cost of the project in terms of ROI (return on investment). With this information, Bill can see how much the project is likely to earn in increased revenue, and therefore have a clearer idea of how much he's willing to spend to achieve these increased earnings.

Other stakeholders will not be directly affected by the project, but will want to have a say in how the project is implemented, and may have the power to block the project if they aren't contented. Regulators, security folk, and system administrators are good examples of this sort of role.

The actual role of the various stakeholders in achieving business goals and delivering business value is often overlooked. If users don't use the application in the expected way, the software may not realize the benefits you expected. Looking at things from another angle, a very effective way to identify the features that are most likely to support the business goals and provide real value is to think in terms of